

Disarmament and International Security Committee

Anti-Satellite Weapons and the Militarization of Outer Space

Background Guide

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Directors Letter

Dear Delegates,

My name is Marie Harmsworth and it is my distinct honour to serve as your Director for the Disarmament and International Security Committee at SPAMUN. Alongside my Chair, Renie Zhu, and my Assistant Director, Abigail Rozmus, we are delighted to welcome you to Southpointe Academy Model United Nations eighth iteration. Whether this is your very first conference or your last, I sincerely hope that you are ready to contribute your efforts, speeches, and funny speech starters in order to create a flourishing and fruitful debate environment.

As a senior at Lord Byng Secondary School in my fourth and final year of MUN, I have been working tirelessly to ensure an invigorating and exhilarating experience which every delegate will engage in fruitfully. Model UN has served as a cornerstone of my high school experience. Starting as a nervous delegate who spoke a grand total of one time at my first conference, I rapidly developed a growing passion for this captivating sport. I strive to create an equally engrossing experience for each and every delegate who enters my committee room.

At this iteration of SPAMUN, DISEC will be exploring Anti-Satellite Weapons and the Militarization of Outer Space. With the rapidly evolving tumultuous state of our global political environment, this topic is quickly becoming critical to every nation. With a destroyed satellite's ability to shut down the internet and connectivity for millions, this topic stands at the forefront of DISECs concerns.

As a committee, your task is simple: to debate, discuss, and collaborate to develop a comprehensive and pragmatic resolution paper which addresses all facets of Anti-Satellite Weaponry. As a delegate, your role is to bring your ideas on how to multilaterally solve the dire concern of ASATs alongside your fellow delegates. Position papers—due [insert date here] —are highly encouraged and will be mandatory for award consideration.

I wish that all delegates not only read the backgrounder but engage in their own research to grasp this topic to the fullest extent. I implore each and every one of you to enter the committee room with excitement, passion, and a readiness to collaborate with your peers. The only way that we as a committee

will solve this crisis is if we enter SPAMUN with pragmatic, logical, and solution oriented solutions which will ultimately benefit all countries involved.

If you have any questions or concerns please contact us at _____. I wish you all the best wishes in successful research and preparation. See you all in October!

Sincerely,
Marie Harmsworth
Director of the Disarmament and International Security Committee

Committee Description

Established in 1945, the Disarmament and International Security Committee serves as the first United Nations General Assembly.¹ As one of the six primary committees, it was developed as an international platform where nations worldwide would have the platform to discuss issues regarding peace and security.² Therefore, it emphasizes the principles of disarmament and international regulation of weaponry and arms.³ DISEC has stood behind some of the world's most imperative solutions surrounding many arms and security treaties. One that I am sure many of you have heard of is the Biological Weapons Convention, protecting civilians worldwide from (insert fancy words for bad weapons damage humans cause harm)

Every single human on this earth has been affected by peace and security concerns. While many of us in Vancouver have never truly experienced war firsthand, we must remain cognizant of the hundred of millions of humans suffering as a result. It is imperative that we as a committee recognize the role we have as committee members to protect our societies from the pain and terror which so many people experience in war.

In the present day, the Disarmament and International Security Committee continues to stand as one of the principle non-governmental bodies which aids peace and security worldwide. While resolutions created in DISEC continue to be non-binding to this day, the committee's ability to encourage and support nations for independent nations to implement can be effective if done properly. As delegates in this committee, it is important to ensure that your solutions are not only of sound logic, but are created bearing in mind the optional nature of such resolution, and develop them in such a way that it is favourable for every nation to implement these aforementioned formal recommendations.

Topic Overview

¹ <https://www.imuna.org/nhsmun/nyc/committees/disecc-disarmament-international-security-committee/>

² Ibid.

³ <https://www.un.org/en/ga/first/>

Emerging out of the Cold War with the 1957 launch of Sputnik 1, anti-satellite weapons and the weaponisation of outer space are a largely contemporary issue which has rapidly become one of the forefront geopolitical spatial challenges.⁴ While for centuries, the exploration of outer space and discovering the vast universe beyond earth was largely a scientific domain, it has in recent decades transformed into a fervent battle between numerous global hedgemons.⁵ The weaponisation of outer space—defined as the utilisation militaristic technology beyond earths atmosphere—can be boiled down into a couple key issues: Anti-Satellite Weaponry and the imminent risk of Kessler Syndrome, and the outdated and blatantly inapplicable international frameworks in place to monitor the geopolitical and militaristic realm of outer space.⁶

In this modern era, we as a society are deeply and unequivocally reliant on technology—satellites being one of the most imperative things keeping the world running as it does in this time. Within the past century of so, there has been a massive global shift away from traditional analog systems—exchanging them for digital networks which rely heavily on satellites in order to keep the interconnective nature of these systems alive and running.⁷ Satellites have fundamentally transformed the way society operates. From the inception of Sputnik 1—the worlds first satellite—to this day, satellite technology has served as a landmark technological development which has allowed human society to evolve rapidly into a highly connected, rapidly developing society. [please add in somewhere later when you are editing this that like there are also like research and space satellites ykykyk] [a;so the industry growth it has cause—modern economic development—internet—wifi—fosteres economic opportunities etcetc.⁸ From calling a friend, to creating television broadcasting, and protecting the weather, to GPS, satellites play role in one's life more than one could ever imagine.⁹ In essence, satellites have served as a catalyst for some of the human race's most integral developments.

While capitlaizing on some of the worlds greatest modern advancements may seem simple, as humans develop increasing dependence on these sattlities, they begin to become substantive targets of attacks. The destruction of powerful satellites which manage the bulk of a nations connectivity are increasingly becoming targets of attacks—bringing up the concerns of Anti-Satellite Weaponry. Anti Sattelite weaponry kinetic—meaning through the means of physical disruption—and non kinetic—through cypersecurity, hacking or the jamming of signals—alike have risen to become a major concern in todays society. Established in 1966, the OST—the outer space treaty—is the only substantive legal framework currently in place to protect our societies from the dangers of outer space militirization.¹⁰ While it protects the exploration of outer space when used to a benefit to nations and in the interest of mankind, and protects the freedom of outer space, it is void of any substantive or targeted regulation that prevents

⁴ <https://www.nasa.gov/history/dawn-of-the-space-age/>

⁵ <https://aerospace.csis.org/the-future-of-military-power-is-space-power/>

⁶ <https://atlasinstitute.org/from-exploration-to-escalation-the-challenges-of-space-weaponisation/>

⁷ https://newspaceconomy.ca/2025/02/11/modern-dependencies-the-impact-of-complex-systems-on-society-and-civilization/#google_vignette

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<https://diversedaily.com/satellite-impact-on-society-the-broad-social-and-economic-effects-of-satellite-technology-on-everyday-life/>

⁹ Ibid.

¹⁰ <https://www.unoosa.org/oosa/en/ourwork/spacelaw/treaties/introouterspacetreaty.html>

the damage of anti-satellite weaponry. And equipped the ability to destroy, disrupt, and damage a nation's infrastructure, there is a rapidly growing interest in both employing said weapons—as well as a dire urge to strengthen the inadequate legal regulations which currently surround it.¹¹

As a committee at SPAMUN 2026, the Disarmament and International Security committee must strive to bridge the gap between the archaic and frankly borderline irrelevant existing international frameworks, and develop pragmatic and effective solutions. While not every nation in this battle holds the same stake in the space race, the collaboration and cooperation of delegates will be what protects the wellbeing and the sacrosanct right of every nation to profit as a result of space technology. Space is not a warzone, and it is up to this committee to ensure it stays that way.

Historical Backgrounder

On October 4th 1957, a small object weighing only 83.6 kilograms and no larger than a beach ball was launched into space for the very first time. While this may seem insignificant now, this marked the launch of a Soviet satellite—Sputnik 1—the world's first ever satellite.¹² In the midst of the Cold War's frigid climate, this seemingly insignificant action launched a wave of terror and fright throughout the world.¹³ This vast demonstration of pure technopolitical supremacy triggered a paradigm shift in the geopolitical powers of the two global hegemonies at the time, the USSR and the United States; an action which initiated the infamous space race.¹⁴

At its core, Sputnik 1 was a largely a scientific exploration whose success was considered a landmark technical achievement for space technology at the time.¹⁵ Though the demonstration of this vast scientific superiority raised a question for the Americans: if they can launch Sputnik, what else can they launch?

A second wave of terror hit upon the launch of a subsequent Sputnik 2 on November 3rd 1957, transporting the first living creature—a stray dog from the streets of Moscow named Laika—into space for the first time.¹⁶

¹¹ <https://atlasinstitute.org/from-exploration-to-escalation-the-challenges-of-space-weaponisation/>

¹² Ibid.

¹³ <https://explaininghistory.org/2025/11/23/the-foundational-fears-sputnik-the-missile-gap-and-the-crisis-of-american-techno-confidence/>

¹⁴ Ibid.

¹⁵ <https://www.nasa.gov/history/dawn-of-the-space-age/>

¹⁶ <https://www.britannica.com/technology/Sputnik>



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These actions by the USSR sent the United States into a state of hysteria, revealing the "missile gap" and shocking inproficiency in the then contemporary technology of intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBM) — the very technology used to launch Sputnik 1, and a technology with the potential to send nuclear warheads to the United States .¹⁸¹⁹ As a response, the Eisenhower Administration in the States at the time quickly sprung to develop the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) in order to parallel the USSR's spatial superiority and battle for technological superiority.²⁰

¹⁷ <https://www.britannica.com/animal/Laika>

¹⁸<https://explaininghistory.org/2025/11/23/the-foundational-fears-sputnik-the-missile-gap-and-the-crisis-of-american-techno-confidence/>

¹⁹ <https://www.britannica.com/technology/R-7>

²⁰ <https://www.nasa.gov/history/monograph10/nasabrth.html>

Timeline of Events